the atomic energy department. Add to that, his proximity to none less than the Prime Minister of the country, and it made Sarabhai a man not just with a purpose, but the means to achieve it. It could have been more than disconcerting for the US.

I have never been an insider of the country's atomic energy programme, but my proximity to Sarabhai allowed glimpses of his long-term plans as much as his immediate priorities. One such plan came to fruition on 18 May 1974, two-and-a-half years after Sarabhai's death, when Buddha smiled and India became the first nation outside the five permanent members of the United Nations Security Council to trigger a nuclear explosion. There may be nothing on record, definitely not in public domain, to show Sarabhai's involvement in India's show of nuclear might in the Rajasthan desert, but it will be foolish on anyone's part to think that a nation could explode a nuclear device in less than three years. Sarabhai, no doubt, was at the core of the Pokhran exploit.

Homi Bhabha handpicked Sarabhai to succeed him as the head of the space programme evidently because of his eagerness to make India a nuclear power too. Bhabha, in a way, was the World War's gift to India. Bhabha, then a nuclear physicist in Britain, was on a vacation in India in September 1939 when the war broke out, prompting him to stay on in India. Bhabha took up a teaching job at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore, then headed by C V Raman. How he persuaded then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru to initiate India's nuclear programme and launch the Atomic Energy Commission barely a year into independence is history. The bomb was Bhabha's goal. In Sarabhai, Bhabha found a scorer.

When Air India flight Kanchenjunga 'accidentally flew' into Mont Blanc in the morning of 24 January 1966, as Wikipedia puts it, Bhabha, 56, was among the 106 passengers who died. Five years later, Sarabhai, 52, was found dead in a hotel room in Trivandrum.